The 8-Week Budget Remodel Roadmap

Same Home. A Brighter You.

A Step-by-Step System to Plan, Budget, and Complete Your Home Remodel Without Going Over Budget



PLAN SMARTER

STAY WITHIN BUDGET

REMODEL WITH CONFIDENCE

A HOME YOU LOVE

SMALL STEPS. BIG CHANGES.

30 DAY SPACES

Kitchen Remodel Roadmap

Cap-first kitchen planning — what you can document, and what a qualified trade must do

Akarsh Priyadarshan

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Interior designed for Amazon KDP print (6 × 9 in) and Kindle.

1 interior image in this book was generated with AI tools and reviewed by the author. All diagrams were drawn from the measurements in the text.

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CHAPTER

One cap, one contingency rule

This book is a kitchen planning roadmap for compact US homes and rentals. It is not a building-code manual, an electrical or gas guide, a plumbing license, a structural design, or legal advice. Some scenarios use apartments in Indian cities as compact-space illustrations. They do not define the market. Prices are in US dollars. Measurements are in inches. Example dollar amounts are illustrations, not typical remodel prices. 1 inch equals 25 mm if you need a conversion. Manufacturer instructions, the lease, building rules, licensed trades, and the authority having jurisdiction take precedence. You may plan, measure, document, and photograph. Qualified professionals perform electrical, gas, structural, and permit-required plumbing work. A score, a heat map, or a contingency formula in this book does not

authorize unsafe work. Contingency lives inside the budget cap. It is not added on top. There is one method in this book. Ignore older notes that used a separate 8 percent plus risk-score formula, a competing 10–12 percent band, or a 12–15 percent band as a second calculator.



DAY 1

The cap is the ceiling, not a wish

IN THIS APARTMENT

Budget worksheet: a renter in a Pune 1BHK — used here as a compact-rental illustration — wrote one number and then priced a full cabinet, gas, and electrical remodel against it.

> **Write the cap first. A cosmetic refresh and a systems remodel are different projects.**

Today's output: a written kitchen cap in USD, labeled illustrative until you have local quotes, plus three buckets — must have, should have, will not do.

Dollar figures in this book are planning scenarios. Actual cost varies by city, labor, appliances, existing conditions, and whether a qualified person must open walls. A small paint-and-hardware refresh is not the same budget as moving plumbing or electrical.

State whether the cap includes professional labor, materials, permits, waste, and contingency. If labor is extra, write that. Weekly budget review (the old notes said CFO review — that is a metaphor, not a job title) starts after this page exists.

DO THIS

1. Write the USD cap
2. List must / should / will-not
3. State what the cap includes

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

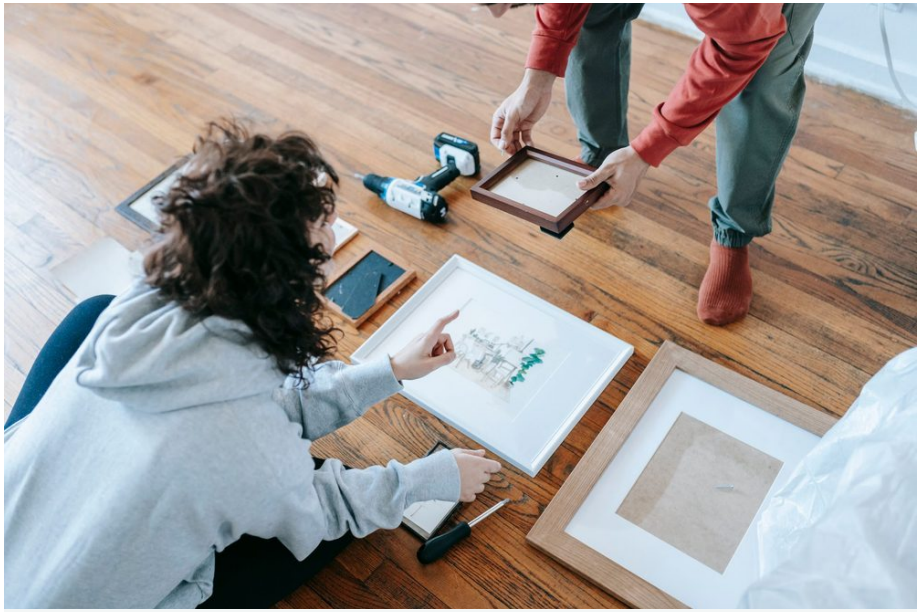
Treating an example cap as a realistic price for every kitchen.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Write the USD cap

List must / should / will-not

State what the cap includes



DAY 2

One contingency method, inside the cap

IN THIS APARTMENT

Kitchen measurement error: two formulas on the same sheet produced two different leftover amounts.

> **Reserve twelve percent of the cap as contingency. Cut other lines if risk is high. Do not add contingency on top of the cap.**

Today's output: the same cap, with working cost at eighty-eight percent and contingency at twelve percent, summing to one hundred percent of the cap. Category lines under working cost must add up to the working-cost total. Contingency is not copied into those categories.

Contingency sits inside the cap

Parameter	Value
Budget cap	**Hard ceiling**
Working cost	**Everything except the reserve**
Contingency reserve	**Twelve percent of the cap**
Working plus reserve	**Equals the cap**

One method. Do not add a second cushion on top.

Worked illustration, not a quote: cap 10,000 USD. Working cost 8,800 USD. Contingency reserved 1,200 USD. Example cosmetic split of the 8,800: demolition and waste 900, qualified fixture electrical or plumbing 2,000, finishes 2,200, fixtures 2,400, permits and fees 600, tools 700. Those six lines equal 8,800. Plus 1,200 reserved equals the cap. Do not also add 10–12 percent on top.

Illustration: ten thousand USD cap

Parameter	Value
Eighty-eight percent	**Working cost**
Twelve percent	**Reserved, do not spend in planning**
Sum	**Must equal the cap**
If risk is high	**Rescope or cut categories**

Label this scenario illustrative. Quotes replace these numbers.

People overrun 15–25 percent when they have no cap and they spend the reserve during planning. Contingency is not a forecast of that overrun. If unknowns are high (old plumbing, moisture, complex permits), rescope first. If you still proceed, raise the reserved percent only by reducing other categories so the cap does not move. Do not use 8 percent plus half a percent times a risk score.

DO THIS

1. Enter cap, working cost, reserve
2. Make categories sum to working cost
3. Cross out extra formulas

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

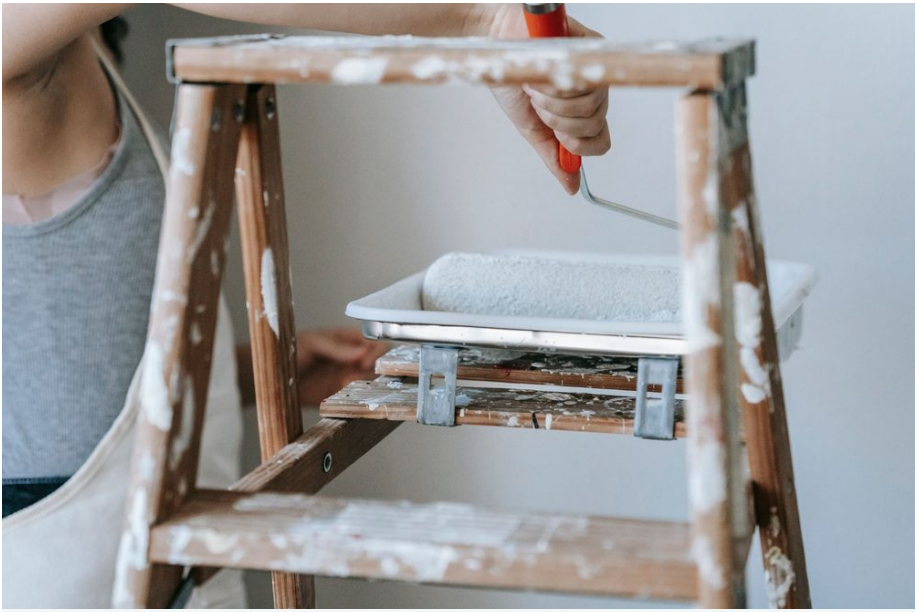
Running the risk-score formula and the 12 percent rule on the same cap.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Enter cap, working cost, reserve

Make categories sum to working cost

Cross out extra formulas



DAY 3

Freeze the kitchen scope, or rescope before you buy

IN THIS APARTMENT

Inspection hold point: a backsplash add was priced after cabinets were ordered.

> **If it is not in the frozen kitchen scope, it is a change order or it is out.**

Today's output: a kitchen scope freeze — rooms (kitchen only), outcomes, exclusions, and the change-order gate. Bathroom and living-room examples in older notes were general remodel process, not this project's scope.

Variance means planned versus actual cost, time, or quantity. Estimate at Completion (EAC) is the current forecast of total spend if you continue. If EAC will break the cap, rescope before purchasing.

DO THIS

1. Write exclusions
2. Name the approver
3. Date the freeze

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Keeping the cap and adding a wall of cabinets that were never in the freeze.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Write exclusions

Name the approver

Date the freeze



CHAPTER

Renters, buildings, and local rules

Permit requirements vary by jurisdiction and project scope. Building-owner or association approval may be required even when a municipal permit is not. Electrical, gas, structural, and plumbing work must be assessed against applicable local requirements. This book is not a substitute for official approval or professional code interpretation. Load-bearing walls are not the only structural concern. Shared stacks, exhaust, waterproofing, and fire assemblies can be affected.



DAY 4

Renter and apartment limits before tools come out

IN THIS APARTMENT

In this rental courtyard kitchen, the tenant wanted a new hood duct through an exterior wall.

> **Written permission first. Restoration last. Freestanding is not automatically allowed.**

Today's output: a renter sheet — written owner or landlord permission; housing or building-management approval; limits on drilling, structural work, plumbing, and exhaust; waterproofing and drainage limits; where the water, electrical, and gas shutoffs are and who may operate them; noise and demolition windows; waste and debris path; restoration obligations when you leave.

Renter kitchen hold points

Parameter	Value
Owner or landlord	**Written**
Association or management	**If the building requires it**
Drill, plumb, exhaust	**Ask before any hole**
Utility shutoffs	**Who is allowed to touch them**
Waste path	**How debris leaves**
Restoration	**Who pays to put it back**

A blank is a Hold, not a maybe.

A load-bearing wall is not the only stop. Shared plumbing, fire-rated assemblies, and building exhaust can be off limits even if the wall is not load-bearing.

DO THIS

1. Get written permission
2. Map shutoffs you must not operate if restricted
3. List restoration duties

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Ordering a through-wall hood because the listing called it easy DIY.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Get written permission

Map shutoffs you must not operate if restricted

List restoration duties



DAY 5

Confirm the city. Do not invent the code

IN THIS APARTMENT

Contractor bid example: two quotes assumed no permit because a neighbor in another city had not needed one.

> **Ask the local building department and a qualified person. The book does not pick your permit.**

Today's output: city and jurisdiction; property type; owner or renter approval; applicable permits; responsible professional; inspection or certification requirements; approval status and reference number.

Jurisdiction fields

Parameter	Value
City and jurisdiction	___
Property type	___
Owner or renter approval	**Written**
Applicable permits	**List or none confirmed**
Responsible professional	**Named trade**
Inspection requirements	**If required**
Reference number	**Number or none**

This book does not issue approvals.

Pune, Bengaluru, Mumbai, or Delhi in a scenario is an illustration of a dense apartment kitchen. US readers still confirm the US city, county, and utility rules that apply to this address.

DO THIS

1. Fill city and property type
2. Call or look up what applies
3. Record the professional who will pull permits

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Copying a permit list from a blog for a different county.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Fill city and property type

Call or look up what applies

Record the professional who will pull permits



CHAPTER

Safety gates, then skill — never a DIY score as permission

Safety and legal constraints are gates. A low composite score cannot override them. Return on investment is a money-ranking tool, not a safety criterion. If risk or regulatory status is uncertain, stop and refer.



DAY 6

These kitchen tasks are not DIY in this book

IN THIS APARTMENT

Unexpected concealed condition: a homeowner scored 'swap the range' as DIY because the composite was low.

Gates first. Scores never authorize gated work.

Today's output: each gated task marked professional, with what you may still document (photos, model numbers, desired location) and what must be verified before anyone starts.

Gated work — score does not apply

Parameter	Value
Energized circuits	**Shock and fire**
Panel or rewiring	**Panel and new circuits**
Gas lines	**Leak, fire, carbon monoxide**
Structural or fire assemblies	**Building and neighbor harm**
Hidden plumbing alterations	**Water into floors below**
Permit-required tasks	**Local rules decide**

Plan and document only. Qualified people perform the work.

Outside DIY in this book: work on energized circuits; new circuits, panel work, or significant rewiring; gas line install, relocation, or modification; structural changes or work affecting load-bearing or fire-rated elements; hidden plumbing that can leak into floors or neighbors; any task that local rules require a licensed or qualified person or a permit to perform.

You may photograph, measure, and write the desired outcome. A qualified person plans and performs the gated work. Verify shutoff authority, permits, and insurance before they start.

DO THIS

1. List gated tasks on this kitchen
2. Write who will perform them
3. Do not score gated tasks as DIY

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Using a DIY score of twelve or less as permission to land a new circuit.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

List gated tasks on this kitchen

Write who will perform them

Do not score gated tasks as DIY



DAY 7

Score leftover tasks for skill and time, not ROI

IN THIS APARTMENT

Materials delivery problem: painting scored well; hanging a heavy cabinet on an unknown wall did not.

> **After gates pass, remaining work can be ranked by skill, access, and time. ROI is a separate shopping order.**

Today's output: one framework. Gate columns: safety and code/legal — fail means professional, stop. Then skill and time for the leftover tasks only. Do not average ROI into the same score.

One DIY framework

Parameter	Value
Safety gate	**Professional — do not score**
Code and legal gate	**Professional — do not score**
Skill	**Rank leftover tasks only**
Time and access	**Rank leftover tasks only**
Return on investment	**Shopping order, not safety**
If anything is uncertain	**Stop and refer**

A number never overrides a gate.

There is no twelve-point DIY pass. There is no 'no factor above 3' alternative matrix. A task with a serious hazard stays professional even if every other number is low.

DO THIS

1. Cross gated tasks off
2. Rank leftover work by skill and time
3. Keep ROI on a money list only

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Letting a high ROI paint a live-wire swap as DIY.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Cross gated tasks off

Rank leftover work by skill and time

Keep ROI on a money list only



DAY 8

Stop and refer when you are not sure

IN THIS APARTMENT

Final punch-list discovery: a warm outlet cover was found after a 'passed' plug-in tester.

> **Uncertain wiring, gas smell, structural movement, or active leak is a stop.**

Today's output: a stop list on the fridge — suspected wiring faults, overheating, damaged outlets, missing protective devices, gas odor, sagging structure, hidden wetness. Leave the area safe if you can without becoming the trade. Call the qualified person and the owner if you rent.

You plan placement of outlets and appliances on paper. You do not open the panel.

DO THIS

1. Post the stop list
2. Save trade and landlord numbers
3. Do not troubleshoot live equipment

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

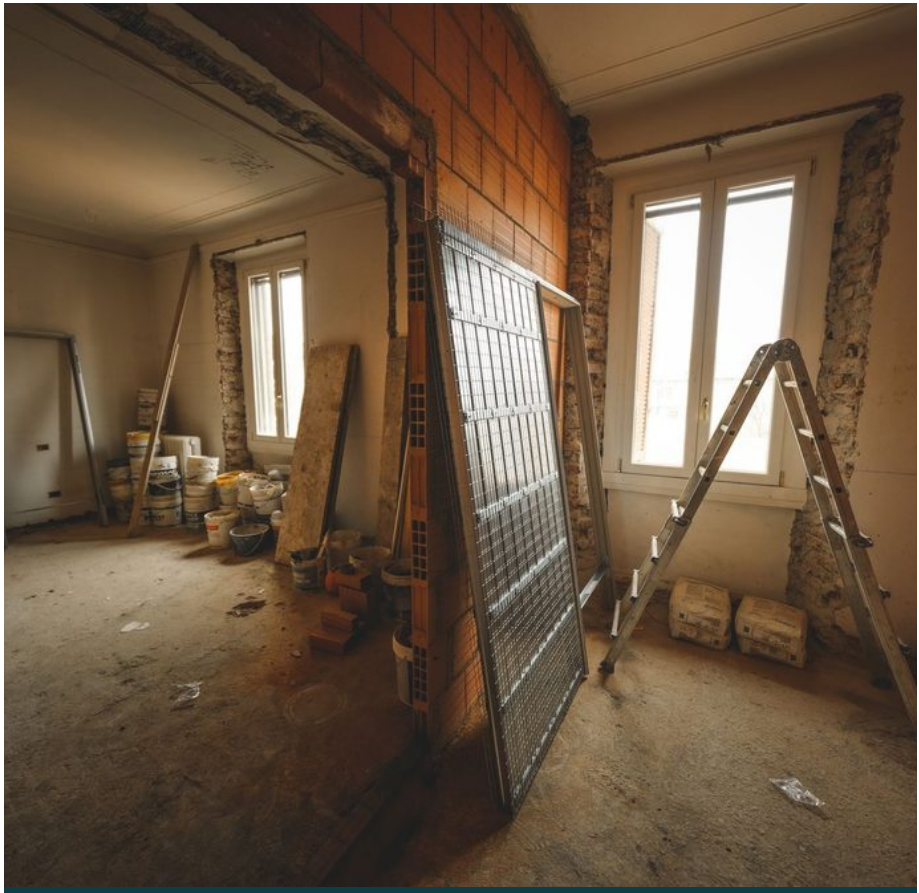
Resetting a breaker repeatedly until it stays on.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Post the stop list

Save trade and landlord numbers

Do not troubleshoot live equipment



CHAPTER

People, bids, and paper that actually apply here

Contract and payment protections depend on local law. For a significant project or material contractual risk, get appropriate legal advice. Lien waivers are not universal and do not work the same in every country. Confirm what payment protections exist where the kitchen is. A license or insurance page does not guarantee workmanship.



DAY 9

Verify the contractor; do not stop at a certificate photo

IN THIS APARTMENT

Contractor bid example: three photos of other kitchens and an expired insurance card.

> **Identity, current coverage, similar work, and who signs off specialist trades.**

Today's output: identity and business details; qualifications or licenses confirmed with the appropriate local authority when that applies; recent references for similar kitchens; insurance current and relevant to this work; which trade

performs and signs off electrical, gas, and plumbing; who pulls permits and who corrects failed inspections; written scope and a documented change-order process.

DO THIS

1. Verify identity and lookups
2. Call a similar-kitchen reference
3. Write who owns permits

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Hiring from a license selfie.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Verify identity and lookups

Call a similar-kitchen reference

Write who owns permits



DAY 10

Compare bids. Confirm which protections your law actually gives you

IN THIS APARTMENT

Budget worksheet: the lowest number omitted hood make-up and haul-away.

> **Same scope, same exclusions, same tax treatment — or it is not a comparison.**

Today's output: a bid sheet — labor, materials, allowances, lead times, who buys appliances, exclusions, permit responsibility. Do not treat a generic lien-waiver clause as valid everywhere. Ask what payment protections are legally available at this address, or get legal advice.

Paper that depends on local law

Parameter	Value
Lien or similar protections	**Confirm locally or get advice**
Payment safeguards	**Milestones plus evidence**
Warranty	**Scope, duration, claim path**
Disputed work	**Written process**

Ask what exists here. This book is not a contract form.

Payment safeguards you can still use: documented milestones, photos or inspection evidence before the next payment, a defined final-payment condition, and a written process for disputed work. A warranty is useful only if scope, duration, exclusions, and how to claim are written down.

DO THIS

1. Line up equal scopes
2. Mark legal terms as confirm locally
3. Require written warranty details

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Signing because the bid mentioned lien waivers and a one-year warranty with no details.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Line up equal scopes

Mark legal terms as confirm locally

Require written warranty details



DAY 11

Nothing is in the job unless it is written

IN THIS APARTMENT

Unexpected concealed condition: extra electrical was done on a handshake.

> **Change orders in writing, except the urgent-safety path in the execution chapter.**

Today's output: a signed or saved scope, payment schedule, and change-order rule. Routine changes wait for written approval. That is not a reason to leave an active leak or a fire risk until a cooling-off period ends — see Day 19.

DO THIS

1. Save the scope
2. Save the payment schedule
3. Point to the change-order rule

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Paying extra cash on site for 'while we are here' with no note.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Save the scope

Save the payment schedule

Point to the change-order rule



CHAPTER

Kitchen pieces have to fit this kitchen

Nominal cabinet width is not a fit. Manufacturer installation instructions, clearances, fuel type, ventilation, and delivery path decide. Recirculating hoods are not the same as ducted exhaust.



DAY 12

Order against the kitchen sequence, not a mood board

IN THIS APARTMENT

Materials delivery problem: the sink arrived after the countertop was templated to a different bowl.

> **One roster. Long-lead items first. Substitutions need a written change.**

Today's output: a kitchen materials roster — item, model, quantity, lead time, backup source, who accepts delivery. Do not mix bathroom vanities into this list.

DO THIS

1. List every kitchen item
2. Mark long-lead orders
3. Name the backup source

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Buying a 'kitchen look' faucet that needs a hole the sink does not have.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

List every kitchen item

Mark long-lead orders

Name the backup source



DAY 13

Compatibility is more than width

IN THIS APARTMENT

Kitchen measurement error: a 30-inch range was ordered for a 30-inch opening that ignored handle clearance and gas connection.

> **Fit the opening, the utilities, the vent, and the service access.**

Today's output: for each appliance — dimensions and manufacturer clearances; electrical supply and circuit requirements (documented, installed by a qualified person); gas or other fuel if applicable; ventilation and exhaust type (ducted vs

recirculating); water and drain connections; countertop and cabinet cutouts; door swing and service access; manufacturer install rules; delivery path and packaging inspection; warranty conditions and whether authorized install is required.

Appliance compatibility fields

Parameter	Value
Size and clearances	**Opening and listed clearances**
Electrical supply	**Document; qualified install**
Gas or other fuel	**If the appliance uses it**
Ventilation	**Ducted or recirculating**
Water and drain	**Sink and dishwasher too**
Access and warranty	**Cutouts and swings**

Nominal width is one field, not the decision.

DO THIS

1. Measure the real opening
2. Match fuel and vent type
3. Check door swing and service access

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Assuming a matching nominal width is a complete fit.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Measure the real opening

Match fuel and vent type

Check door swing and service access



DAY 14

Delivery and procurement verification before anyone installs

IN THIS APARTMENT

Materials delivery problem: the wrong dishwasher model was accepted because the box was the right color.

> **Wrong, damaged, or incomplete goods do not go into the opening.**

Today's output: correct product and model; quantity and dimensions; visible damage; accessories and install parts; compatibility with the approved design; warranty and invoice kept; storage and protection; confirmation the install date still works.

Delivery cutoff

Parameter	Value
Product and model	**Matches the order**
Quantity and dimensions	**Count and measure**
Visible damage	**Photo if not**
Paper trail	**Invoice and warranty**
Storage	**Dry and secure**
Install date	**Still the right day**

Do not install a maybe.

DO THIS

1. Match model to the roster
2. Photograph damage before the driver leaves
3. Hold install if parts are missing

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

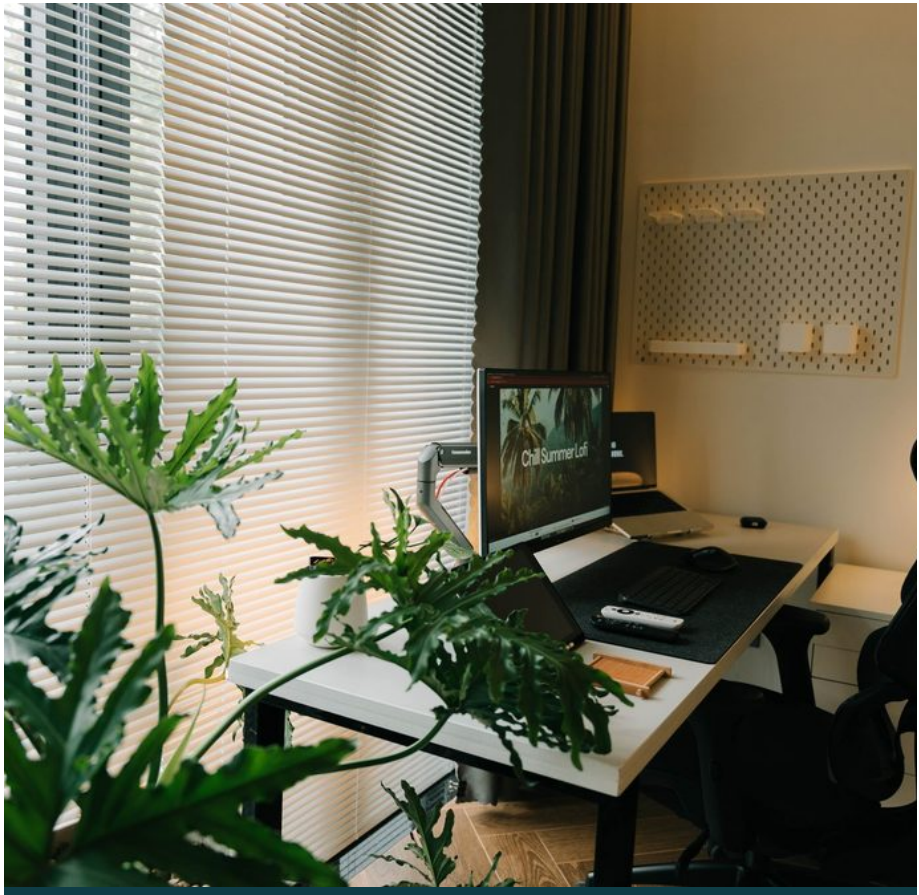
Signing for a crushed carton to keep the crew busy.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Match model to the roster

Photograph damage before the driver leaves

Hold install if parts are missing



CHAPTER

A kitchen sequence, not a general-house sequence

Bathroom and living-room stories in older notes were process examples. This chapter is kitchen only. The order below is a planning aid. Actual order depends on design, existing conditions, and applicable requirements. It is not a method statement for every site.



DAY 15

Kitchen execution in twelve planning steps

IN THIS APARTMENT

Inspection hold point: drywall closed before the rough plumbing check.

> **Do not close walls or set cabinets on unverified rough work.**

Today's output: this kitchen's sequence, with N/A where a step does not apply, not a copied bathroom story.

Kitchen sequence — planning aid

Parameter	Value
Steps 1–2	**Permissions and utilities**
Steps 3–4	**Measure then buy**
Steps 4–5	**Qualified isolation then demo**
Steps 6–7	**See hidden work**
Steps 8–10	**Before cabinets**
Steps 11–12	**Then punch and handover**

Site conditions can change the order. Do not skip gated trades.

1) Scope, permissions, utility identification. 2) Appliance and fixture measurements. 3) Procurement and delivery verification. 4) Isolation of electrical, water, and gas by qualified personnel where required. 5) Demolition and waste. 6) Inspection of concealed conditions. 7) Rough plumbing and electrical by qualified people. 8) Inspection and testing before closing walls or installing cabinetry. 9) Wall, floor, and backsplash prep. 10) Cabinets and countertops. 11) Fixture and appliance connections by the people the manufacturer and local rules require. 12) Functional testing, punch list, handover.

DO THIS

1. Number the steps for this kitchen
2. Mark N/A honestly
3. Put a hold before closing walls

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Following a living-room paint sequence and skipping kitchen rough-in checks.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Number the steps for this kitchen

Mark N/A honestly

Put a hold before closing walls



DAY 16

Look, then close

IN THIS APARTMENT

Unexpected concealed condition: scorched sheathing behind a range outlet.

> **If you cannot see it later, photograph it now and get the right eyes on it.**

Today's output: a concealed-conditions pass — photos of opened walls, who assessed wiring, pipes, and structure, and a written go or Hold before cover-up.

DO THIS

1. Photograph open walls
2. Get the named professional's go
3. Hold cabinets if Hold

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Closing because the inspector's window was inconvenient.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Photograph open walls

Get the named professional's go

Hold cabinets if Hold



DAY 17

One daily kitchen log

IN THIS APARTMENT

Budget worksheet: three notebooks duplicated the same leak and still missed the cost.

> **One template. Weekly budget review reads this log; it does not replace it.**

Today's output: a blank log with fields — date and work area; people and trades; work completed; materials delivered and used; inspections or hold points; safety issues; damage or unexpected findings; photos; hours; costs incurred; blockers and next actions; responsible person.

Daily kitchen log fields

Parameter	Value
Date and work area	___
Trades on site	___
Work completed	___
Deliveries	___
Inspections	**Hold or pass**
Blockers and owner	___

One row per day. Do not run a second unofficial log.

DO THIS

1. Print or duplicate the fields
2. Fill today's row
3. Attach photos

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

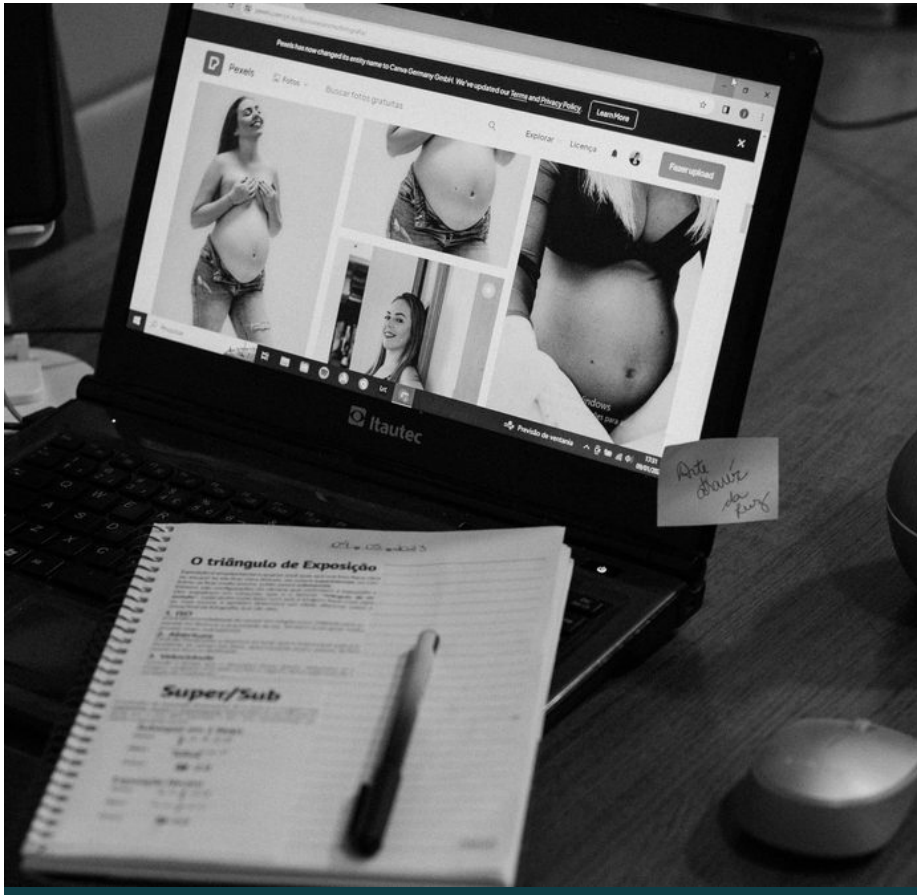
A group chat as the only record.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Print or duplicate the fields

Fill today's row

Attach photos



CHAPTER

Stops, changes, and risks that are not décor

Green on a heat map does not make a safety hazard acceptable. Cost impact and safety impact are different ratings. Unresolved high-severity hazards stay gated regardless of the number.



DAY 18

Hidden conditions protocol

IN THIS APARTMENT

Unexpected concealed condition: blackened wiring in a kitchen soffit.

> **Stop. Photograph. Protect. Get the right professional. Do not price it as a casual extra.**

Today's output: the protocol on site — stop work; photograph and document; protect the area and prevent further damage; get an appropriate professional assessment; decide whether safety, code, schedule, or cost is affected; record the scope change and who pays; get written approval before non-emergency extra work.

Hidden conditions — stop first

Parameter	Value
Stop	**Now**
Photograph	**Evidence**
Protect	**Limit damage**
Assess	**Right trade**
Impacts	**Safety, rules, money, time**
Scope and funds	**Who pays**
Written approval	**Except true emergency path**

Non-emergency extras wait for written approval.

Examples: concealed leaks, bad substrate, damaged wiring, unexpected pipe routes, structural concerns.

DO THIS

1. Stop and photograph
2. Call the right trade
3. Do not proceed without the written path

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

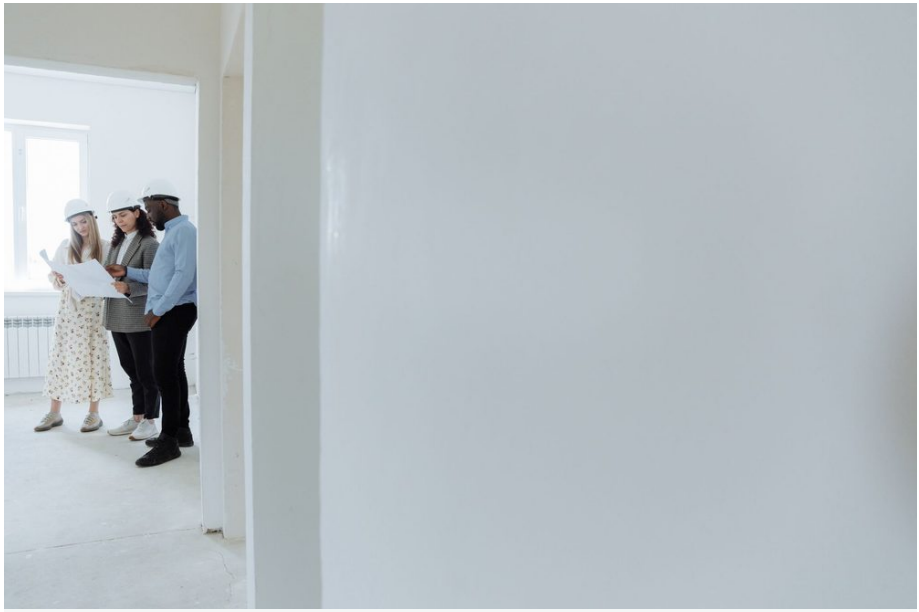
Tiling over a soft spot to keep the calendar.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Stop and photograph

Call the right trade

Do not proceed without the written path



DAY 19

Written changes, with an urgent-safety exception

IN THIS APARTMENT

Inspection hold point: a burst supply line during demo.

> **Routine waits. Imminent harm does not wait for a cooling-off period.**

Today's output: three buckets. Routine change: written approval before work. Urgent protective action: immediate action to prevent injury, active water damage, fire risk, or other imminent harm, then prompt notice and documentation. Regulated correction: follows the professional, inspection, or authority requirements.

Three kinds of change

Parameter	Value
Routine	**Write first**
Urgent protective action	**Protect people and the building**
Regulated correction	**Follow the authority or trade**

Emergencies are narrow. They are not a style upgrade.

Urgent record: description, reason, who authorized, work performed, cost, follow-up inspection. Then fold it into the budget as a documented change.

DO THIS

1. Label the change type
2. If urgent, record the six fields
3. Bring it into the budget the same day

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

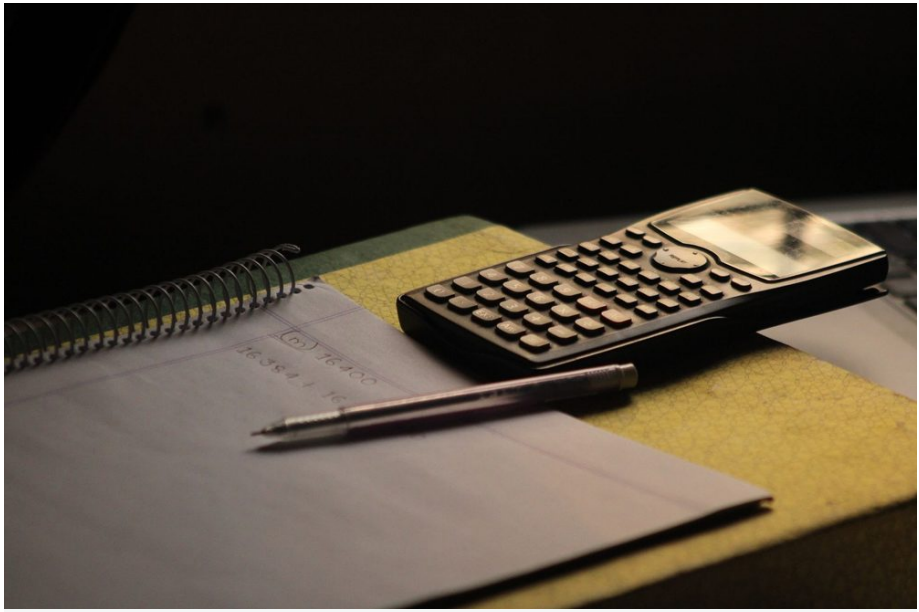
Using 'emergency' to add a skylight.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Label the change type

If urgent, record the six fields

Bring it into the budget the same day



DAY 20

Heat-map scores have definitions

IN THIS APARTMENT

Budget worksheet: a live-wire risk scored green because it felt unlikely this week.

> **Likelihood and impact are 1 to 5 with words. Safety is not averaged into cheap.**

Today's output: each kitchen risk with likelihood 1 (rare) to 5 (expected this project), impact 1 (nuisance cost or delay) to 5 (injury, fire, major water, legal stop), owner, due date. Cost and safety are separate. If safety is high, treat it as red even when likelihood is low.

Heat map is not a safety stamp

Parameter	Value
Likelihood 1 to 5	**Rare to expected**
Impact 1 to 5	**Nuisance to injury or legal stop**
Cost vs safety	**Do not mix into one cell**
Owner and due date	**Name and date**
Yellow or red move	**Add control and date**
High-severity hazard	**Restrict and refer**

High severity stays gated even if the product is a small number.

When a risk moves from green to yellow or red: add a control, a date, and a person. Unresolved high-severity hazards: restrict the area and get professional help. A green box is not acceptance of a shock or gas hazard.

DO THIS

1. Define 1–5 in your log
2. Split cost vs safety
3. Assign owner and date

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Leaving a gas-flex concern green because the number was four.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Define 1–5 in your log

Split cost vs safety

Assign owner and date



CHAPTER

Test what you can. Do not fake the rest

A plug-in tester is not a full electrical inspection. Air at a hood grille is not proof of a legal exhaust system. Water-heater settings are not the same as tap temperature. Do not adjust a water heater just to chase a number from this book.



DAY 21

Functional checks without false comfort

IN THIS APARTMENT

Final punch-list discovery: a tissue 'passed' on a recirculating hood that never had a path outside.

Record what you observed. Do not certify the house.

Today's output: a test sheet that states limits. Hot water: comfort and scald risk depend on the system, local rules, and who uses the sink. Do not raise or lower the water heater yourself solely because a 120°F target was missed. Tap temperature is not the heater setting. Ask a qualified person if adjustment or replacement is needed.

What these tests do not prove

Parameter	Value
A temperature target	**Not a DIY heater adjustment**
A plug-in tester	**Not a full inspection**
Air at the grille	**Not duct or code performance**
Kitchen vs bath fan	**Not the same system**

Observation is not a certificate.

Electrical: a plug-in tester can catch some wiring errors on that receptacle. It does not prove every safety condition. It does not replace required inspection. Stop on suspected faults, heat, damage, or missing protection — Day 8.

Ventilation: kitchen exhaust is not a bathroom fan. Recirculating hoods filter and return air; they are not ducted exhaust. Airflow at the grille does not prove duct route, discharge, or required performance. Check the installed type against the plan and the manufacturer's instructions.

DO THIS

1. Write heater vs tap as unknown unless measured by a qualified person
2. Log tester limits
3. Name hood type

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Calling the kitchen safe because a tissue stuck to the hood and a tester showed two lights.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Write heater vs tap as unknown unless measured by a qualified person

Log tester limits

Name hood type



DAY 22

A kitchen closeout binder documents records, not 'proof of compliance'

IN THIS APARTMENT

Punch-list discovery: no one knew the dishwasher serial or the shutoff under the sink.

> **The binder holds what you have. It does not prove every rule was met.**

Today's output: appliance models and serials; warranty registration if you choose to register; approved changes and final scope; photos of concealed services; shutoff locations; cleaning and maintenance from the makers; contractor and trade contacts; invoices and payments; inspection or approval documents you actually received.

Kitchen closeout contents

Parameter	Value
Appliances	**Model and serial**
Warranties	**If you register**
Concealed services	**Open-wall photos**
Shutoffs	**Where they are**
Care sheets	**Maker instructions**
Approvals and invoices	**What you received**

Records on file, not a blanket compliance stamp.

Do not label the binder proof of compliance. It documents available approvals and records.

DO THIS

1. Collect serials
2. File photos of concealed work
3. Store invoices and any approval papers

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Writing 'compliant' on the cover because a permit card was photocopied.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

- Collect serials
- File photos of concealed work
- Store invoices and any approval papers



DAY 23

Weekly budget review, in plain words

IN THIS APARTMENT

Budget worksheet: the reserve was spent on nicer hardware in week two.

> **Variance is planned minus actual. EAC is the current forecast to finish.**

Today's output: weekly budget review (not a corporate CFO meeting) — spent to date, variance by kitchen category, remaining contingency, EAC versus cap, stop if EAC will break the cap.

Estimate at Completion means your current forecast of total cost if you continue as now. If that forecast exceeds the cap, rescope. The reserve is not a shopping fund.

DO THIS

1. Compute variance by category
2. Compute EAC
3. Protect the reserve

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Calling the project fine because cash remained while EAC was already over.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Compute variance by category

Compute EAC

Protect the reserve



CHAPTER

Two kitchen budget stories, both labeled illustrations

Use separate examples for a cosmetic refresh and a systems remodel. Neither number is a quote.



DAY 24

Cosmetic refresh versus systems remodel

IN THIS APARTMENT

Budget worksheet: one 10,000 USD line tried to fund both a cosmetic refresh and a gas-range swap.

> **If gated work is in scope, the illustration cap may be too small. Raise the cap in writing or cut the gated work.**

Today's output: pick one story. Cosmetic: paint, hardware, lighting replacements that do not need new circuits, maybe a qualified person swapping like-for-like devices. Systems: moving water or gas, new circuits, cabinets, counters — priced with real local quotes, contingency still inside the cap.

The 8,000–12,000 USD band in older notes was an illustration for a modest refresh, not a universal remodel budget, and not rupees. Replace it with current local quotes.

DO THIS

1. Choose cosmetic or systems
2. Re-run Day 2 math
3. Get quotes before calling it feasible

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Forcing a gas relocation into a cosmetic cap.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Choose cosmetic or systems

Re-run Day 2 math

Get quotes before calling it feasible



CHAPTER

The kitchen bid sheet

Equal scope or it is not a comparison.



DAY 25

Fill the bid sheet for this kitchen only

IN THIS APARTMENT

Contractor bid example: one bid included haul-away; two did not.

> **Lowest price with missing haul-away is not lowest.**

Today's output: completed bid comparison for the frozen kitchen scope. Confirm locally any payment or lien language. Go back to Days 9–11 before signing.

DO THIS

1. Equalize exclusions
2. Name permit owner
3. Read the warranty paragraph

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Picking a bid that omitted the hood because the number looked friendly.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Equalize exclusions

Name permit owner

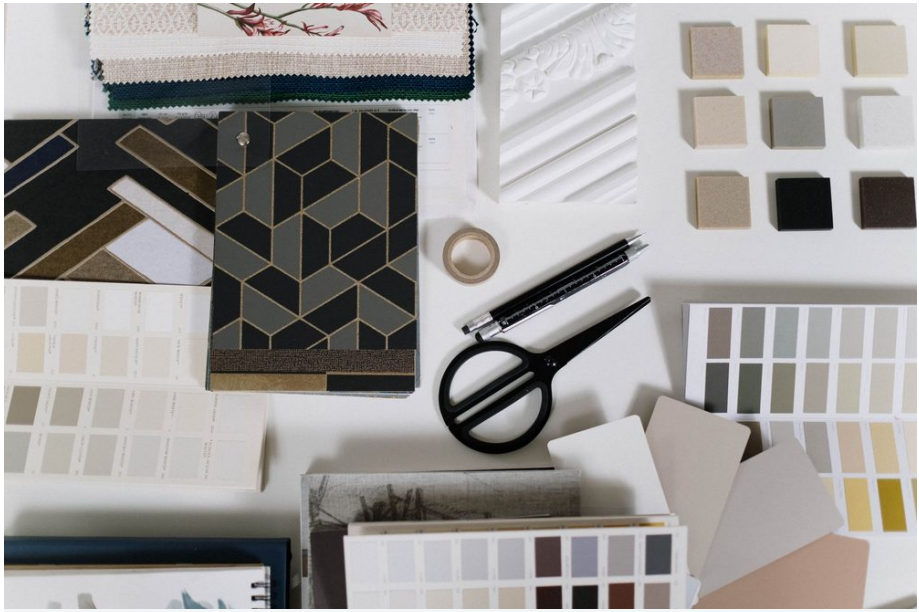
Read the warranty paragraph



CHAPTER

Live in the kitchen, then stop buying

A punch list is for this kitchen. Do not start a bathroom with leftover contingency.



DAY 26

Punch list after a real cooking session

IN THIS APARTMENT

Final punch-list discovery: the refrigerator door hit the island on the first grocery load.

> **Use the kitchen as you will use it. Then list defects.**

Today's output: punch list from cooking, cleaning, and opening every door. Include appliance serials still missing from the binder. Unresolved high-severity items stay restricted.

DO THIS

1. Cook one meal
2. Open every door
3. File remaining Holds

WHERE THIS GOES WRONG

Signing off because the paint matched.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Cook one meal

Open every door

File remaining Holds



DAY 27

Handover, then stop

IN THIS APARTMENT

Punch-list discovery: leftover contingency was treated as a backsplash fund.

> **If the kitchen works and Holds are closed or scheduled, stop.**

Today's output: leftover reserve stays reserve until punch items that are actually required are done. Do not invent a second room. Confirm renter restoration notes if you do not own the place.

DO THIS

1. Close the punch or schedule it
2. Keep leftover as leftover
3. File restoration notes if you rent

> **WHERE THIS GOES WRONG**
>
> Starting a bathroom with kitchen leftover money.

TODAY'S OUTPUT

Close the punch or schedule it

Keep leftover as leftover

File restoration notes if you rent



30 DAY SPACES

Your next room starts here

More room kits and measured layouts — same series language, same clear numbers. This book helps readers plan a kitchen refresh against a hard cap. It does not interpret code, replace a licensed trade, or guarantee a price, permit, or damage-free rental.

Akarsh Priyadarshan